

KF Introduction to NHG

Chs. 9-10: *Self-Effacing Solution and Morbid Dependency*¹

Last week we looked at the expansive solution to our conflicts and insecurity. This week I'd like to show you how the self-effacing solution is no healthier; in fact, it is the least satisfactory solution for managing anxiety and for functioning in society. While appearing humble and spiritual, self-effacing people sacrifice their own development and growth for the sake of a family, a cause, a job, or a religious institution. They are gripped by the compulsive need to be helpless, dependent, and self-sacrificing, and they have strong taboos about confrontation and self-assertion. Self-effacing types allow situations and people to devour their time, attention, and resources because they have a need to see themselves as generous, good, and unselfish. Taboos against self-assertion make them very vulnerable to exploitation, and they often feel resentful when others cannot guess what they want or need and don't offer them the care that they crave. Their pride is invested in the illusion that they are loving, caring and in need of care. When circumstances threaten to expose this illusion, their pride blinds them to the truth. When threatened, self-effacing people compulsively and unconsciously resort to strategies like dishonesty and manipulation. Their default reaction is to accuse others and excuse themselves. These devices help them function in the world and preserve their private fiction that they are saintly, loving, and good.

It is difficult to get an honest or direct response from a self-effacing person, and this evasion of the truth often deludes or frustrates those around them. Plain speaking is rarely an option for this type because their ability to recognize and express their own reality has atrophied. They don't even know what their reality is! They have a taboo about truth in general, and this taboo serves their idealized search for glory. In order to force others to solve their problems and rescue them, they create an illusion of helplessness, which, in particular, attracts expansive types who are looking for opportunities to assert their authority and take control. Self-effacing types avoid the challenge of personal development and therefore forfeit the opportunity to discover who they actually are. When an institution or another person chooses not to take responsibility for the self-effacing type's problems or doesn't offer them the support they believe they deserve, self-effacing people see themselves as abused victims of all the unloving, selfish, and evil people in the world. They find it impossible to learn, grow, or explore their options since they believe that everywhere they turn they will find difficulties and oppression. Self-effacing people naturally assume the role of the victim. In fact, feeling and acting like a victim is one of the most prevalent characteristics of this type.

Satan tried to persuade Jesus to jump off the temple to prove or test God's ability to miraculously rescue Him. Self-effacing neurotics are temple-jumpers. They actively get themselves into difficulties and then hope that God and others will take care of them. Special attention reinforces their belief that they are spiritual and valuable.

King Saul was self-effacing. He was chosen by God to rule Israel, but he refused to grow into the shoes of a king. Saul's chronic inability to withstand negative public opinion undermined his development as a leader. As his self-hate grew, he imagined himself to be the victim of an expansive type who both fascinated and terrified him. Saul made no effort to be honest with God and was not interested in discovering what God in mind when He made him king.

Self-effacing types suffer more than the other types and are, therefore, more interested in changing their lives. With God's guidance and care, and through their own KF work, they can learn to take responsibility

for themselves, develop interdependence in the community, and discover their unique contribution in the world.

¹Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).